

3. Von Soden noted, correctly, that **K^r/f³⁵** MSS are characterized by far fewer variants than MSS of other types. His explanation was that his **K^r** was a revision imposed by ecclesiastical authority; it was a controlled text. Within the discipline, the notion of a controlled text was extended to the whole Byzantine text. For example, on page 11* of the English ‘Introduction’, the editors of the *Editio Critica Maior* of James¹ refer to the Byzantine text (which includes **K^r/f³⁵**) as being “carefully controlled”. **K^r/f³⁵** is by far the largest, and most cohesive (internally consistent), line of transmission within the broad Byzantine river, so if the Byzantine bulk was controlled, **K^r/f³⁵** would be more so.

Now then, if a text is ‘controlled’, someone has to do the controlling—if there is no controller, there can be no controlling. So who are the possible candidates? I see three possibilities: human beings, Satan, God. So far as I know, all those who refer to the Byzantine text as ‘controlled’ exclude the supernatural from their model; so for them, the controlling is done by human beings, independent of supernatural influence. Since the alleged control had to operate for more than a millennium, it could not be done by a single individual. But who could control the whole Mediterranean world? For over a thousand years the Roman Church used Latin, not Greek. Was there ever a functioning central authority among the Orthodox Churches? Certainly not for a thousand years, and not for the whole Mediterranean world. So who did the controlling?

Not only that, but the supposed controlling was evidently rather lax, since the MSS are full of random mistakes, quite apart from shared dependencies. Consider the conclusion reached by F. Wisse after he collated and analyzed 1,386 Greek MSS containing chapters 1, 10 and 20 of Luke (three complete chapters). He described 37 lines of transmission, plus 89 “mavericks”, MSS so individually disparate that they could not be grouped. Of the 37 groups, 36 fall within the broad Byzantine river, and within them Wisse described 70 subgroups. So what kind of ‘control’ could permit such a situation? I trust that my readers will not think me unreasonable when I say that in the face of such concrete evidence I find the thesis of a ‘controlled’ Byzantine text (excluding the supernatural) to be less than convincing. But then, how shall we account for the comparative uniformity found within it?

I hope that my readers are aware that I personally insist that the supernatural should be included in any model of NT textual criticism. Both God

¹ Aland, Barbara, Mink, Gerd, and Wachtel, Klaus (eds.). *Novum Testamentum Graecum, Editio Critica Maior*. Stuttgart: Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft, 1997.